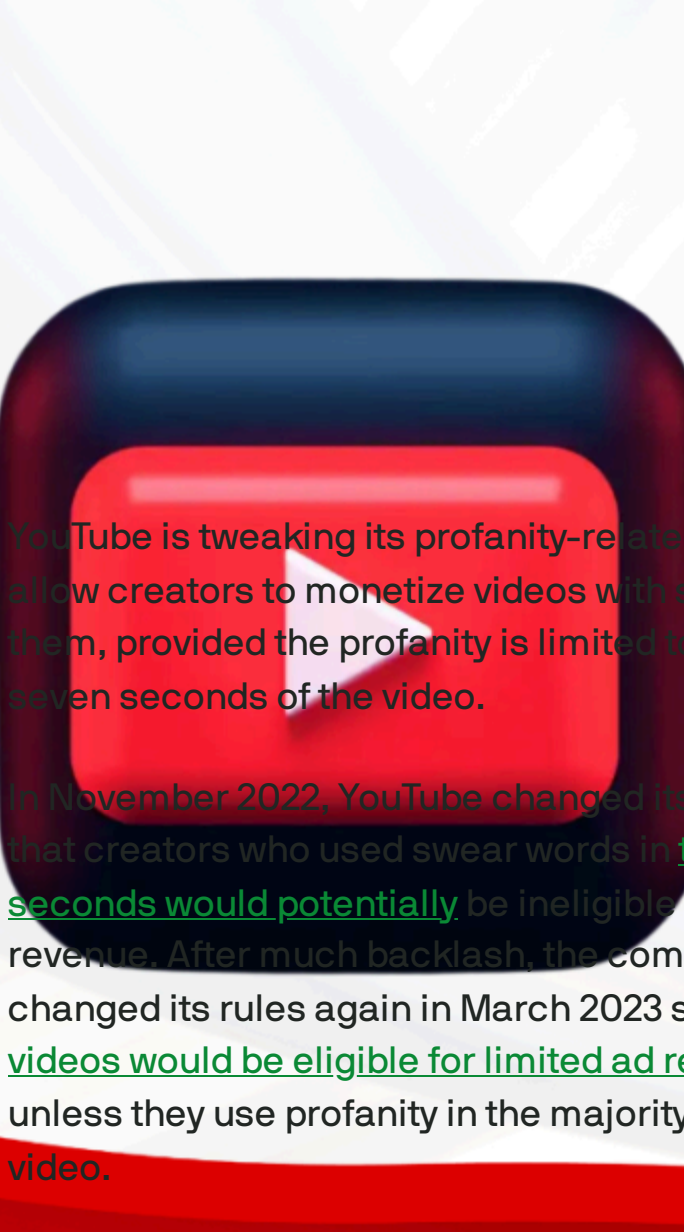


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YouTube loosens profanity rules for monetized videos



YouTube is tweaking its profanity-related rules to allow creators to monetize videos with swearing in them, provided the profanity is limited to the first seven seconds of the video.

In November 2022, YouTube changed its rules so that creators who used swear words in the first 8-15 seconds would potentially be ineligible for any ad revenue. After much backlash, the company changed its rules again in March 2023 so that such videos would be eligible for limited ad revenue, unless they use profanity in the majority of the video.

Announcing the latest changes, YouTube's head of monetization, Conor Kavanagh, said in a video late on Tuesday that the changes of two years ago were made to align YouTube videos with broadcast standards.



"We introduced this guideline to align with broadcast standards; advertisers expected ads on

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YouTube to have a distance between profanity and the ad that just served. Those expectations have changed, and advertisers already have the ability to target content to their desired level of profanity,” he said.

He noted that if creators use moderate or strong swear words in the title or thumbnail, their videos might have limited monetization.

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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

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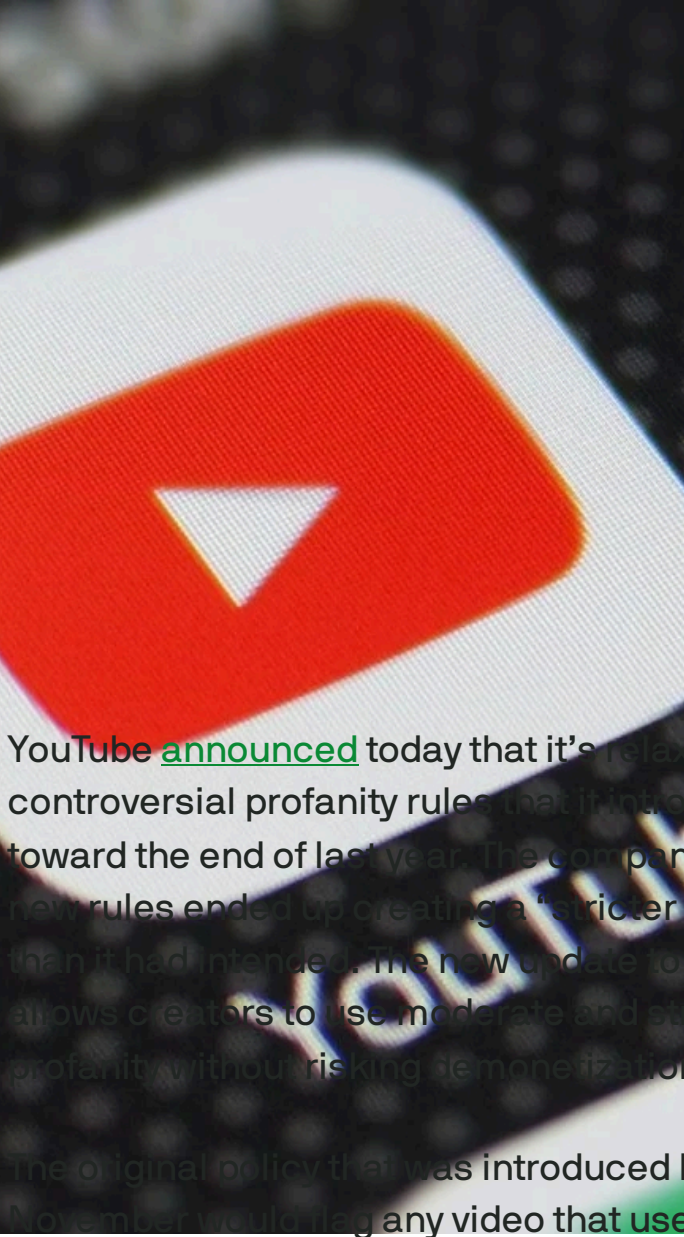
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YouTube relaxes
controversial profanity
and monetization rules

following creator backlash

Aisha Malik — 1:56 PM PST · March 7, 2023



YouTube [announced](#) today that it's relaxing the controversial profanity rules that it introduced toward the end of last year. The company says the new rules ended up creating a "stricter approach" than it had intended. The new update to the policy allows creators to use moderate and strong profanity without risking demonetization.

The original policy that was introduced back in November outlawed any video that [used](#) profanity in the first 15 seconds of the video and made it ineligible for monetization, which meant that YouTube wouldn't run ads on such videos. The change was retroactive and some creators said they had lost their monetization status as a result.

YouTube said back in January that it [planned to modify](#) the new rules.

Although the new relaxed rules don't revert these changes back to the platform's old policy, YouTube is making some changes that will allow creators to be eligible for limited ads if they use strong profanity within the first few seconds of a video. Under the November update, such videos would have received no ad revenue. The company also notes that video content using profanity, moderate or strong, after the first 7 seconds will be eligible for monetization, unless used repetitively throughout the majority of

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the video. Once again, such videos would have received no ad revenue under the November update.

YouTube said that it will re-review videos from creators who had their monetization affected by the November policy.

The company also clarified how profanity in music is treated, and noted that moderate or strong profanity used in background music, backing tracks, intro/outro music can now earn full ad revenue.

Previously, such content would have received no ad revenue. In addition, the use of any profanity in titles and thumbnails will still be demonetized and cannot run ads, as was the case before the update in November.

The new policy goes into effect starting today. It's worth noting that although the new policy doesn't address all of the concerns that creators had and is still somewhat vague, it should make it easier for a big chunk of creators to continue monetizing their videos without having to make major changes.

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It's clear that YouTube is trying to make its massive trove of videos more age appropriate and advertiser friendly, but retrofitting new monetization rules onto a platform like YouTube is a delicate balance, as the past few months have shown.

[YouTube plans to modify profanity rules that prompted creator backlash](#)

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter |

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporter...

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YouTube plans to modify profanity rules that prompted creator backlash

Taylor Hatmaker — 12:02 PM PST · January 14, 2023

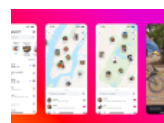
YouTube's gaming community [pushed back](#) against the company this week after some creators saw their old videos demonetized out of the blue.

The culprit is a new policy that the company [introduced back in November](#) in order to make certain kinds of content more advertiser friendly. That change, made to YouTube's advertiser-friendly content guidelines, overhauled the platform's approach to profanity and violence.

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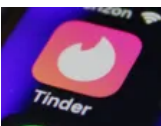
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The good news is that while we don’t quite know what the company will do yet, YouTube is apparently listening to creators’ concerns.

“In recent weeks we’ve heard from many creators regarding this update,” YouTube spokesperson Michael Aciman told TechCrunch. “That feedback is important to us and we are in the process of making some adjustments to this policy to address their concerns. We will follow up shortly with our creator

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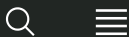
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other profanity would be lumped together instead of differentiated based on severity (e.g. words like “shit” and “fuck” would now be treated the same way). Further, “profanity used in the title, thumbnails, or in the video’s first 7 seconds or used consistently throughout the video may not receive ad revenue,” according to the new policy.

If the swearing kicks in after the first 8 seconds of a video, it’s still eligible, but some of the changes stood to affect a massive swath of videos —many of which were made well before the changes were

announced. Creators started noticing the new policies in effect around the end of December, watching some videos be slapped with new restrictions that limit their reach and ad eligibility.

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YouTube creator Daniel Condren, who runs RTGame, [explored the impact of the policy change](#) on his own channel in a video that racked up more than a million views this week. Condren has been grappling with the enforcement changes in recent weeks after seeing roughly a dozen videos demonetized and his request for appeals rejected.

I am so sorry to have to keep tweeting this – but overnight, 6 more of my videos have now become limited suddenly, including my Best of 2020. No notification from YouTube at all on any of these. This is genuinely awful [@TeamYouTube](#)
pic.twitter.com/UHfSJA1FCt

— RTGame Daniel 🏆 (@RTGameCrowd) [December 29, 2022](#)

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“I genuinely feel like my entire livelihood is at risk if this continues,” Condren wrote on Twitter. “I’m so upset this is even happening and that there seems to be nothing I can do to resolve it.”

YouTube didn’t respond to our follow-up questions about how it plans to tweak the policy, but we’re certainly curious if the platform will roll back enforcement for old, previously published videos that creators might rely on for income.

In the face of emerging regulation targeting social media’s relationship with underage users, the company is clearly trying to make its massive trove of videos more age-appropriate (and advertiser friendly). But retrofitting age restrictions and new monetization rules onto a platform like YouTube is a delicate balance — and in this case the changes had a swift, sweeping impact that gave creators little time to adapt.

Topics: [Creators](#) [Social](#) [YouTube](#)



Taylor Hatmaker

Culture Editor | ✕

Taylor covered social media, gaming and culture at TechCrunch.

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YouTube relaxes advertiser-friendly guidelines around controversial topics, like abortion, abuse and eating disorders

Sarah Perez — 12:31 PM PDT · September 26, 2023

YouTube today announced an update to its [advertiser-friendly guidelines](#) that relaxes some of its rules around controversial issues, including sexual and domestic abuse, abortions and eating

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disorders. The changes will allow YouTube creators to monetize their videos on these topics under some circumstances, though not if they go into graphic detail.

YouTube monetization policy lead Conor Kavanagh shared in [a video posted](#) to YouTube’s Creator Insider channel that the company understands videos that discuss these topics can be a helpful resource to users.

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“So we want to ensure that, wherever possible, controversial issues discussed in a non-descriptive and non-graphic way aren’t disincentivized through demonetization,” he said.

Kavanagh also admitted that some creator communities told YouTube that they feel like they get “more yellow icons” than others — meaning the video has been marked [as not suitable for advertisers](#) — because they discuss these topics.

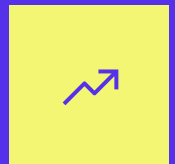
With the change to eating disorder content, specifically, YouTube said that it will align its advertiser-friendly guidelines with its [existing YouTube community guidelines](#). That means creators can’t monetize videos about eating disorders that share triggers like guides around bingeing, hiding or hoarding food, or abusing laxatives. However, educational or documentary content as well as survivor content that references these aspects of eating disorders without promoting such activities won’t be demonetized.

The company had [previously revised](#) its eating disorder policy guidelines years after executives from YouTube and other social media companies,

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including TikTok and Snap, [were questioned by U.S. lawmakers](#) about how their platforms deal with eating disorder content.

Today's update follows [YouTube's relaxing of advertiser-friendly guidelines earlier this year](#) around the use of profanity in videos, which had prompted a creator backlash. The company said its new profanity rules had created a stricter approach than intended and changed them to allow YouTube creators to use moderate and strong profanity without risking demonetization.

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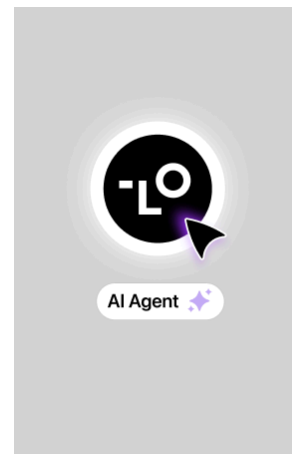
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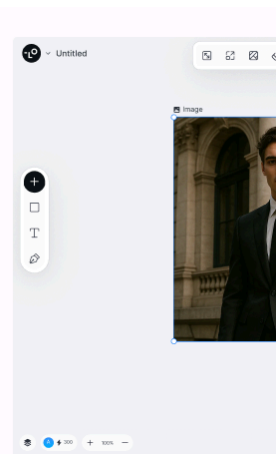
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Previously, any video with profanity within the first 15 seconds of the video made it ineligible for monetization and the change was retroactive. With the rollback, creators would be eligible for limited ads if they used profanity in the first seven seconds of a video or throughout the video while videos with moderate profanity would remain eligible to monetize, regardless of where in the video the terms were used.

Kavanagh referenced those changes in introducing the new guidelines, saying YouTube wanted to make sure it was acting on creator feedback. The creator community had expressed their frustration with the new profanity rules, [saying](#) they hadn't felt well-informed on the impact of the changes at the time they were announced.

“You told us that when we update our guidelines, you value communication of changes, not only through posts to our update log, as well as studio notifications but also hearing the changes explained in clear terms from some of the people who work on a given policy area,” Kavanagh said. “So for updates to our ad guidelines, you can expect more videos like this one, walking you through the changes,” he added.

[YouTube updates its policies on eating disorder content, will ban videos showing ‘imitable behavior’](#)

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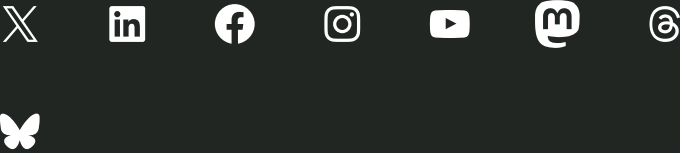
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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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